

Bluff

YOUR WAY THROUGH

Microsoft .NET

To be honest, .NET is a lot of things. Actually, we know so little about .NET that we were ourselves tempted to bluff our way through it this month!

Well, anyway, .NET is “software that connects information, people, systems, and devices. It spans clients, servers, and developer tools”—whatever that means. Just remember to use those words when talking about .NET!

Now, Microsoft .NET consists of many things:

- ❑ The .NET Framework 1.1, used for building and running all kinds of software
- ❑ Developer tools, such as Microsoft Visual Studio .NET 2003
- ❑ A set of servers
- ❑ Client software such as Windows XP

Now you at least know what .NET is. So, what's the .NET Framework? Basically, it is “an integral Windows component for building and running the next generation of software applications and Web services.”

In addition, it is composed of the common language runtime (CLR) and a unified set of class libraries.

Pay attention! The CLR is responsible for run-time services such as language integration, CLR security enforcement, and memory, process, and even thread management.

Here's how to sound as though you know about .NET programming: just say, “I'm currently working on cross-language exception handling. That has a lot to do with strong typing; and runtime binding as well; .NET makes it easy for me to use class libraries to do the exception handling without having to go into the intricacies of Windows Forms.”

Of course, that doesn't make any sense, but then again, who'll ever know?

When The Heavens Opened

While we were busy in a story idea meeting, the Rain Gods were releasing a century of frustration on Mumbai—and we had no idea!

As the warnings started, panic slowly filled our hearts as water seeped into our office. While some preferred to stay back, others were eager to reach home. Preethi, the bravest of us all, firmly wrapped herself in her red windcheater and left—not knowing that her usual two-hour journey was to become a 48-hour ordeal.

People who lived nearby, Ram and our ed Deepak, were home without a fuss. Renuka was lucky too; she reached home in an hour, albeit sans footwear. But some of us—Ishan, Mithun, Raaabo, Aditya, Vijay and Sanket—stayed overnight. We played cricket in the corridors using a stress ball—releasing stress. We ordered pizza, watched movies and slept on the carpeted floor (some used the conference table). Meanwhile, the water level rose

alarmingly and some cafeteria windows were broken to let the murky water out. Then, Raaabo and Vijay decided to brave Mother Nature and headed home at 3 am, despite pleas, and only reached at 11 am.

The rest of us woke up bleary-eyed to another urgent situation—a homesick tantrum-throwing Mithun. Finally, we resolved to troop back. Some walked 40 km for 12 hours through waist-deep—and at times neck-deep—water. Avoiding carcasses, debris and open manholes, it's a miracle we reached home safe and sound.

An enforced holiday followed. And now, post the rains, our meals are served in a small foyer that has sunlight streaming through the glass ceiling. Our café remains uninhabitable. Once, when we tried to lunch there, it was like sitting on the beach... the rain lashed at us through the broken windows: surf's up!

And so is our team—back to our schedules and enjoying every moment!

DIGIT DIARY

a train stops, the game is called *Mind the Bombs!*

The game's Web site invites you to “do your part in the war against terrorism: e-mail this FREE game to all your friends, family and associates to enjoy!”

It also declares itself as “dedicated to the good people of Britain—specifically those individuals directly affected by terrorist activity in London. God save the Queen”.

A disclaimer, evidently by creator Keith Fielor to avoid litigation, states: “This game is in no way affiliated with Transport for London.”

The Sun quoted London Transport spokesman: “Passengers on the Underground and their staff were faced with horrific scenes on July 7. Anybody involved in the making or viewing of this game would do well to stop and think about that. We will never forget those who were killed and injured in the attacks.”

A representative of London Transport Users Committee raged: “Londoners are just getting on with it and we think people should show this game the contempt it deserves. I don't think anybody will find it very funny or very pleasant.”

Remember, a lot of people actually died in the exact same situation—trivialising it does nothing but hurt.

IPODIFIED BABIES

Your Baby's An iPod

Some people have weird ideas—like the folks at ipodmybaby.com. Based on the idea that some people treat their iPods as if they were real babies, this site is selling baby clothes—you can dress babies in them to make them look like iPods!

At the iPod My Baby Web site, you can order a pink, blue, or white baby ‘onesie’ emblazoned with the signature iPod scroll wheel. But why? Obviously because “the only thing cuter than a baby, is an iPodified baby,” as the site states.

People hooked on their iPods will probably find it cute. But the rest of us just don't get it—why would you

want to make a baby look like an iPod of all things?

Anyway, the onesies come in three sizes and cost \$15.95 (Rs 695 approx). Also available at the site is a service called iPod My Photo, which turns a picture of your child—or anybody else—into a mock iPod ad that can be transferred on to T-shirts, greeting cards and more.

Ho-hum. Yet another indicator of how popular Apple's portable music player is...

GAME STUFF FOR REAL CASH

Mugged Online!

A Chinese exchange student has been arrested in Japan on suspicion of an online mugging spree—he used software bots to beat up and rob characters in the online game *Lineage II*.

The student then sold the characters for cash, the *Mainichi Daily News* reported via *New Scientist*. The audacious stunt involved robbing online gamers of several online goods, including the ‘Earring of Wisdom’ and the ‘Shield of Nightmare’.

